



Systems Design

March 21, 2026

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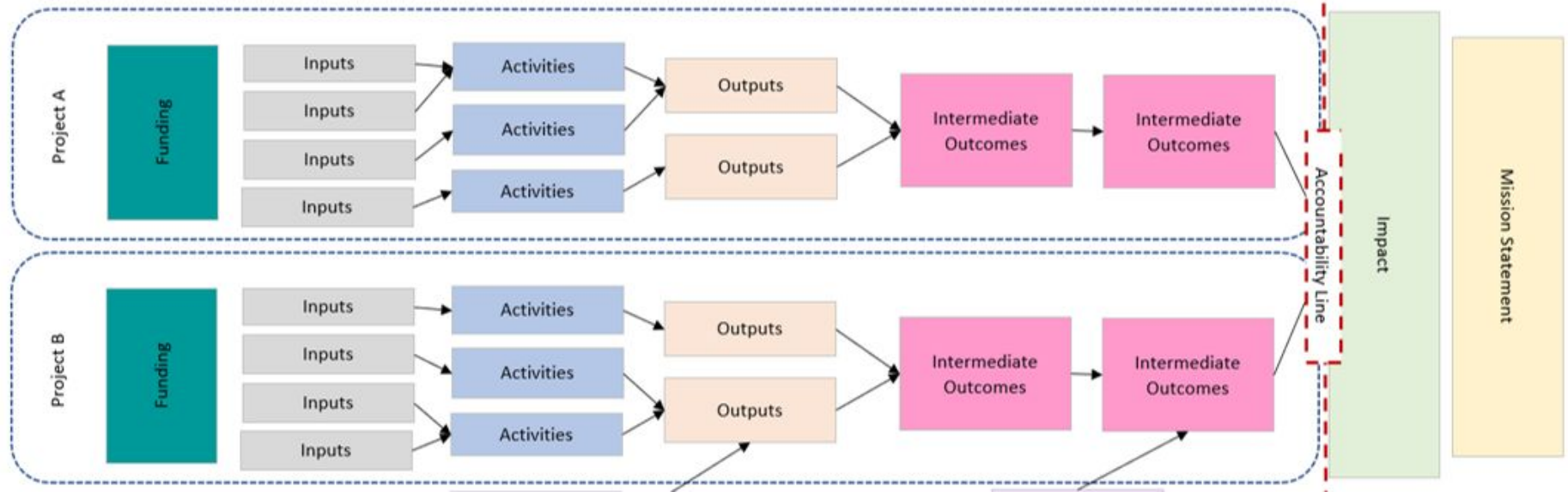
Interviews

Theory of Change

- As a designer, your work should be grounded in impact. What impact do you want your work to achieve—and how can you work backward from that goal?
- One way to connect actions to impact is by creating a theory of change map. Social impact consultant Isabel Vogel describes a theory of change as “an outcomes-based approach which applies critical thinking to the design, implementation, and evaluation of initiatives and programmes intended to support change in their contexts.”
- She outlines two ways to understand a theory of change. First, it can be used as a practical tool to map the logical sequence of an initiative—from inputs to activities, outputs, and ultimately outcomes.
- Second, it can be seen as a deeper reflective process: a dialogue among colleagues and stakeholders that surfaces the values, worldviews, and assumptions that shape how change is understood and pursued.



Theory of Change Template



Logic Model: What vs. Why

Inputs	Activities	Enablers	Intermediate Outcomes	Impacts

In Chapter 3, “Systems Thinking and Design Thinking,” you were introduced to the human-centered design process and how it might intersect with systems thinking (see Figure 7.2).

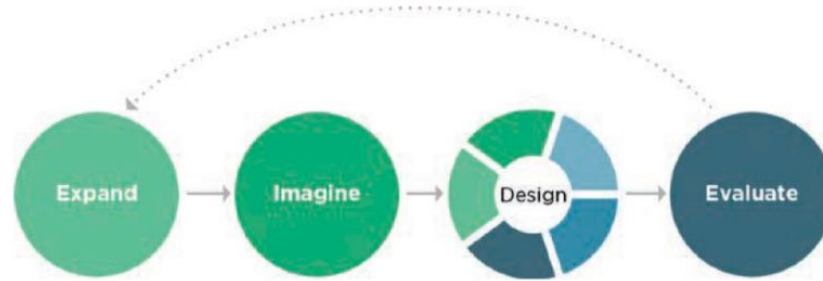


FIGURE 7.2

The circle labeled “Design” represents the five parts of the design-thinking process: gaining understanding (*empathize* and *define*) and taking action by designing (*ideate*, *prototype*, *test*). The *expand*, *imagine*, and *evaluate* phases are how systems thinking can intersect with the design process.

The *expand* phase of the process is represented in the work you’ve done to understand and map the status quo. This phase included your work of doing research, collaborating with stakeholders, and mapping system stakeholders and system forces. Now you will enter a phase in which you imagine interventions, approaches, and possibilities for the problems that you identified in the *expand* phase.

Considerations

- Who has lived experience within the system, and how do I consider their context?
- Who are the decision-makers within the system? Specifically, who holds power?
- What organizations and communities are affected by the system (both directly and indirectly)?



What are your research goals?

- First things first, you'll need to formulate your research goals. What are you trying to understand about a given system?
- As Erika Hall puts it in Just Enough Research, "You'll need to know what decisions are in play (the purpose) and what you're asking about (the topic)."



#GOALS

The Theory of Change

1

+

2

=

3

Articulate
Goals

Map Pathways
& Stakeholders

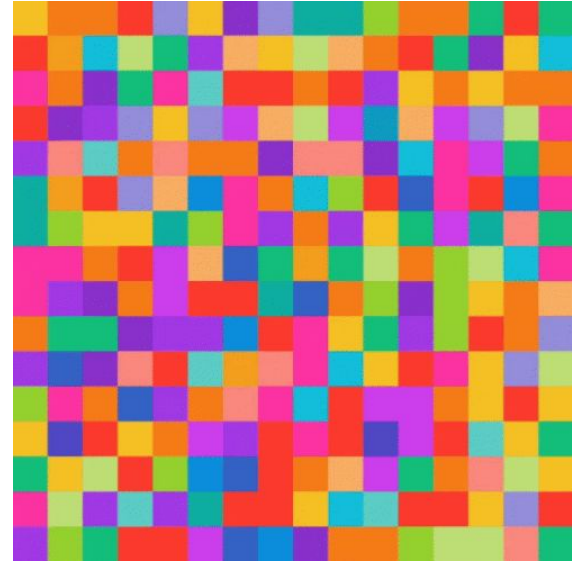
Refine Design
Brief

*Get agreement on steps 1 and 2 to build trust that
your team will find the best design solution*

Elements of a Theory of Change

Isabel Vogel describes the key elements that a theory of change should include:

- **Context:** The current state of the problem the project seeks to influence, including other actors who can affect change.
- **Long-term change:** What the project or initiative ultimately aims to achieve, and who will benefit.
- **Process or sequence of change:** The steps or pathways that are expected to lead to the desired long-term outcomes.
- **Assumptions:** What stakeholders believe about how and why change will happen, including checks on whether the proposed steps are realistic and appropriate for influencing change.
- **Diagram and narrative summary:** A visual map and written explanation that clearly articulate the logic and outcomes of the theory of change.



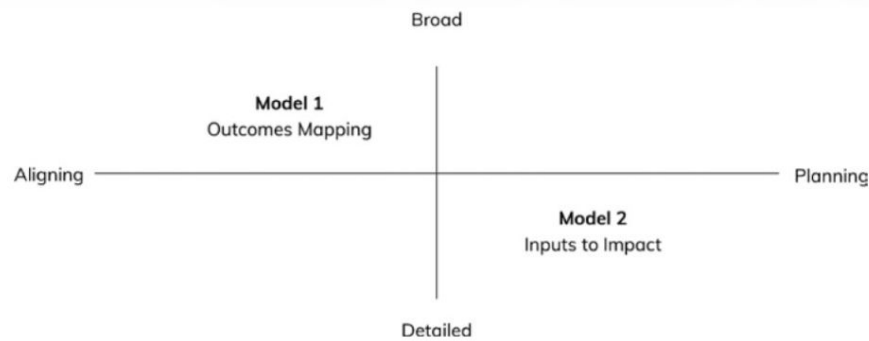


FIGURE 7.7

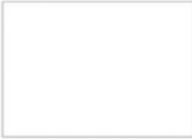
The subsequent frameworks have different objectives but a shared purpose: to align your stakeholders on the action that needs to be taken in order to create change.

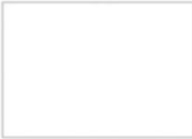
Throughout the process, you might employ different theory-of-change frameworks to elicit responses from your stakeholders, ranging from broad alignment to detailed planning. In addition, you can use a series of frameworks in succession to get more granular in your discussions and decision-making. A structured way to think about each of the frameworks is to understand the following:

- **When to Use:** Are you trying to answer “What should we do?,” “Why should we do it?” or, more specifically, “How should we do it?” The granularity you are seeking determines which framework you might want to use.
- **Objective:** Are you trying to get buy-in from key stakeholders, are you trying to involve new stakeholders whose input is sorely needed, or are you working with a core team to articulate a plan?
- **Components:** What are the key categories that make up the framework?

STEEP

You can structure your ideation by using themes accompanied by the STEEP categories. For example, use the themes that emerged from your status quo systems maps and create a canvas for each theme with the STEEP categories and their descriptions (see Figure 7.6). Encourage your team and stakeholders to generate ideas for interventions in each category. The prompts should allow them to think broadly beyond their own expertise, rather than overindexing on categories that they understand best.

Theme:	Socio-Cultural Social forces (demographics, culture, trending lifestyle habits)	Technological Material innovations, process innovations, digital technologies	Environmental Waste reduction, recycling, and sustainability initiatives
_____			

	Economic Cost of living increases, market prices of commodities, exchange rates, etc.	Political Attitudes and approaches from political participants	
			

Outcomes Mapping

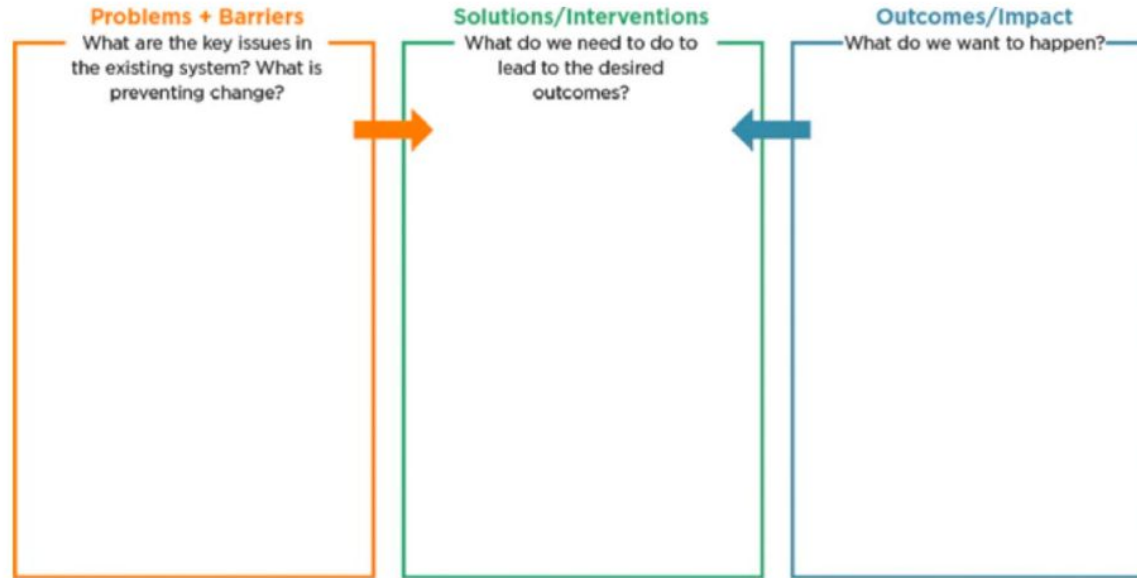


FIGURE 7.8

When mapping outcomes you can think about it as first working backward, from outcomes/impact to solutions/interventions, but you can also think about how to solve existing problems and barriers.

Input to Impact

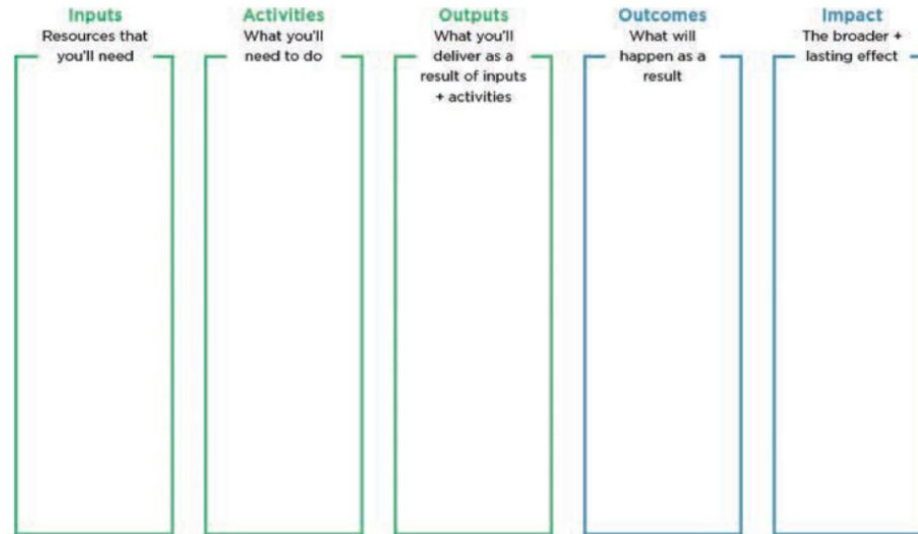


FIGURE 7.12

Everything can be turned into a canvas for adding sticky notes!

CoDesign

- In a systems-thinking project, you will conduct **primary research with a variety of stakeholders**. This includes not only end users of products or services, but also others within the system—such as those who benefit from it, those who are harmed by it, decision-makers, and system experts.
- Through a qualitative approach to exploring the system, you can think of all these participants as different types of experts: **lived experts (people with direct, personal experience—often traditional research participants)**, academic experts, **practitioner experts (those working within the system)**, and policy experts (those who make decisions that influence how the system operates).
- It's critical not only to gather insights from these stakeholders, but also to consider **how to actively engage them in co-design throughout the process**.

Interventions

- So how do you identify interventions within the system you've analyzed?
- One approach is to revisit and analyze the causal loop maps and stakeholder maps you developed in the previous phase. These artifacts can reveal leverage points and areas of opportunity.
- You can then combine these insights with design-thinking methods to brainstorm and ideate potential interventions—ideally in collaboration with your stakeholders—within the existing system.



THEORY OF CHANGE

DIY

THEORY OF CHANGE



VISION

AN EQUITABLE BAY AREA
where all people have the opportunities
and resources needed to thrive

ACCOUNTABILITY

INTEGRITY

RESPECT

EQUITY

VALUES

MISSION

UWBA mobilizes the Bay Area to dismantle the root causes of poverty and build equitable pathways to prosperity.

Through initiatives and policy change, we provide immediate and long-term support for employment, housing, financial stability, and meeting basic needs.



Systems, structures, and policies built on these root causes perpetuate the cycle of poverty. These root causes contribute to inequities in the San Francisco Bay Area, especially for marginalized demographics.

ROOT CAUSES OF POVERTY



To address these, UWBA focuses on four areas:

- HOUSING JUSTICE
- EMPLOYMENT AND CAREER OPPORTUNITIES
- FINANCIAL STABILITY
- MEETING BASIC NEEDS

OUTCOMES

PEOPLE ARE FINANCIALLY STABLE AND PROSPEROUS

- Income that matches our region's cost of living
- Increased opportunities to build credit, savings, and wealth
- Decrease in the racial wealth gap

PEOPLE HAVE HIGH QUALITY LIVING WAGE JOBS AND CAREERS

- Access to social capital and social networks
- Opportunities and support to achieve educational and career goals

PEOPLE'S BASIC NEEDS ARE MET

- Access to services such as emergency shelter & food
- Information and resources needed to navigate the safety net system
- Increased information and support to access public benefits

PEOPLE HAVE SAFE, STABLE AND AFFORDABLE HOUSING

- Increased affordable housing
- Decreased evictions and displacement

DISMANTLE INEQUITABLE POLICIES AND SYSTEMS

Advocate for policies to advance equity, transform the narrative on poverty, and lift community experiences for systemic change.

BUILD EQUITABLE PATHWAYS TO PROSPERITY

Co-create data-driven solutions that prevent and mitigate poverty, scale what works across the region, and provide resources and services directly to our community.

MOBILIZE OUR COMMUNITY

Activate our regional network to tackle poverty by engaging volunteers, raising funds to meet local needs, and partnering across sectors and with community agencies to coordinate services.

STRATEGIES

CONVERGING
to mobilize
partners for
change
POWER

ABILITY TO SCALE
what works
regionally

RESPONSIVENESS
to emerging
community
needs

COMMUNITY
and
engagement
across
sectors
OUTREACH

OUR STRENGTHS

ONLY 1 UNIT OF HOUSING WAS BUILT for every 4 jobs, forcing many families to live in overcrowded and unsafe environments, pay unsustainable housing costs or move farther away

NEARLY HALF OF ALL RESIDENTS in the Bay Area have either low or very low incomes

Between 2010 and 2019, median household income increased by \$250,000 (87%) among highest earning households and ONLY \$4,000 (36%) AMONG LOWEST EARNING HOUSEHOLDS

Black and Latinx residents make up 33% of very low-income families but ONLY 12% OF HIGH-INCOME FAMILIES

Discussion Guide for In-Home Visits

Introduction and Warm-up

Introduction (10 minutes)

- Hello, thank you so much for taking time to speak with us today. (Introduce everyone present.)
- Our conversation today should take about 3 to 4 hours. If you need to pause or stop at any point, please let us know.
- *Have participant review and sign the NDA form.*
- Our team is working on a project that examines how we might improve the banking experience for people like you.
- We want to get to know you and learn about your weekly routine and life. We will be asking some questions, but there are no right or wrong answers. You're the expert today, we are looking to learn from you!
- We may have to ask you for clarifying details about a topic we're less familiar with.
- Is it okay to audio record our conversation today and take photos? This is mainly for our own note-taking purposes. *(If so, start the recording.)*
- Great - let's get started!

FIGURE 4.3

A good discussion guide should be scannable, and include timing on the different sections and activities. It should also be in a format that is printable and easy to reference.

Thank you!
